Newspaper language



The 'language' of newspapers is not just the words that appear in them. As with other media languages, it includes the pictures that are used, different **font** styles and sizes in text and headings and the way these things are put together in the layout of the page.

No aspect of the way newspapers are put together is an accident. At every stage of production people are making decisions which affect the way the paper looks, reads ... and sells!

The copy

Copy is written by journalists called reporters. Writing for newspapers is very different from the sort of writing done by, say, a novelist. News reporters need to get across the maximum amount of information in the shortest possible time. They also aim to get the 'bare bones' of the story established in the first sentence or two – if you are hooked into the story from the very start you will carry on reading.

Journalists are taught to KISS – Keep It Short and Simple. They used also to be taught to get the 'Five Ws' – Who? What? Where? When? Why? – into the first sentences of their story. Now styles of writing for newspapers have moved on. Trying to pack in all five Ws made for indigestible sentences and this rule is not always followed to the letter – but as a guideline it still offers a helpful starting point.

ACTIVITY 4

1 Look at the opening two sentences from the main front page story in three different newspapers: two tabloids and one broadsheet. How many of the Five Ws has the reporter managed to get in for each story?

2 Now do the same for three stories from inside the papers.

The pictures

The first newspapers printed three hundred years ago had very few pictures – and those pictures were drawings because, of course, the camera had not been invented. Nowadays news photographs play a very important part in the whole look of a newspaper, especially the front page.

Look in **7** and **8** at how two newspapers set out their front pages reporting on two of the biggest international news stories of the past 100 years.

Both events were highly significant in the Western world. Almost anyone who was alive at the time remembers exactly what they were doing when they first heard the news of President Kennedy's assassination or the terrorist attack on New York's twin towers. Nearly 40 years separates these two front pages, and the style of newspaper layout changed dramatically between the two events.

ACTIVITY 5

Look carefully at front pages **7** and **8**, paying special attention to the photographs.

1 Why do you think the **picture editors** chose these particular images? What does each tell us about the story?

2 What do you think they wanted the reader to feel about each event? What is it about the way the pictures have been presented that helps to influence how the reader feels?

KEY TERMS

Anchor pin down a particular meaning of a drawing or photograph

Angle the particular point of view a newspaper wants its readers to take on a story

Caption words underneath a picture

Copy printed articles that appear in newspapers

Font the different styles of lettering used in printing papers

Picture editor person responsible for choosing the photographs that go into a newspaper


DAILY EXPRESS

KENNEDY ASSASSINATED

A sniper's bullet

Seconds before: His smile for the crowds

ARRESTED

Lyndon sworn in

Policeman shot

Straight to hospital

7 Front page of the *Daily Express*, 21 November 1963


THE TIMES

When war came to America

Times reporter James Bone was looking up at the World Trade Centre minutes before the twin towers fell from the sky

8 Front page of *The Times*, 12 September 2001

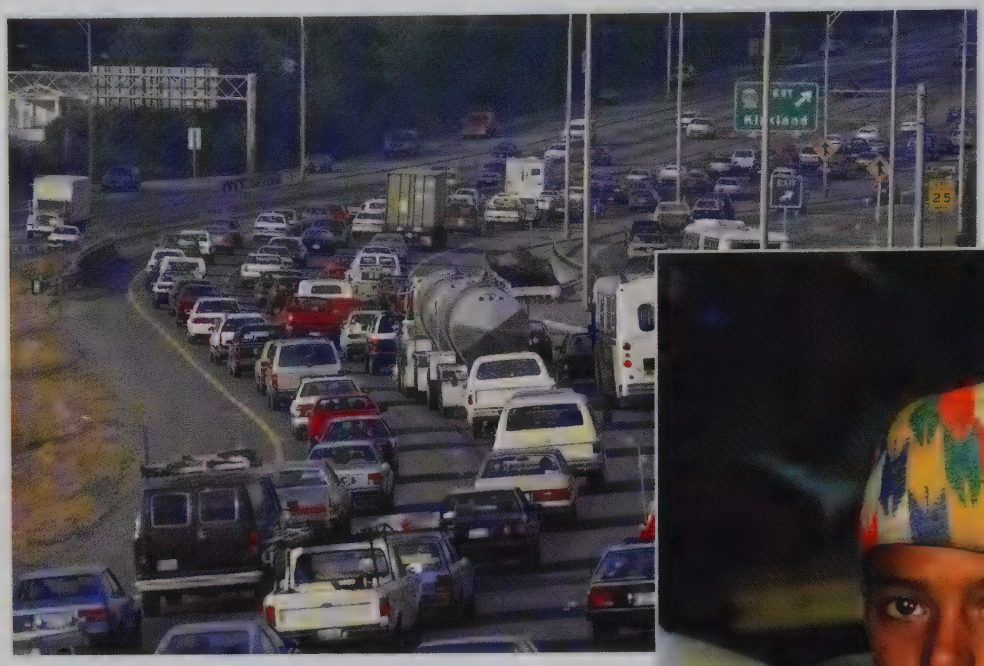
Captions

People say that 'a picture is worth a thousand words'. Certainly the photograph of New York after the attack on the twin towers in **8** says a great deal about the event. The caption that goes with a photograph is also very important because it can **anchor** a meaning – it tries to push the reader towards one **angle** by providing an interpretation for them. Look at photograph **9**. There could be a number of interpretations made of this image. However, choosing suitable captions could alter the way people read it.

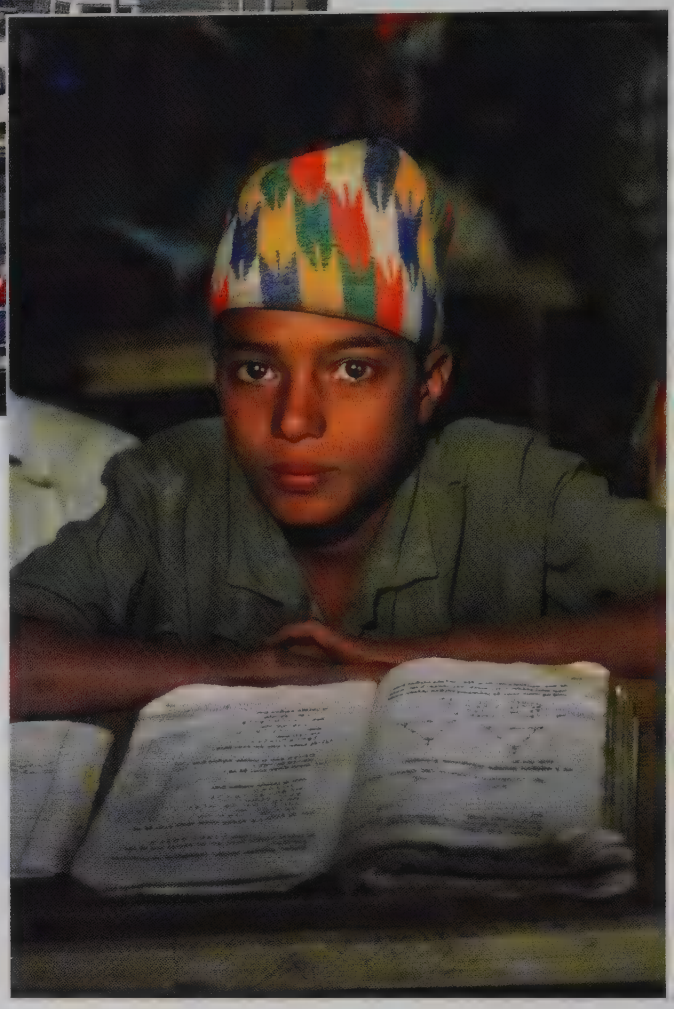
- *South Africa's government has managed to re-house many of its people from tin shacks into solid, brick-built houses:* this caption gives a positive slant on the picture.
- *Unemployment still blights South Africa's townships:* this caption gives a very different, more negative meaning.



9 Street scene in Khayelitsha, South Africa



10



11

ACTIVITY 6

1 Look at photographs **10** and **11**. Write two possible captions to appear in a newspaper for each photograph. One caption should give a positive angle and the other a more negative angle.

2 Compare your captions with those of a partner. What elements of the photographs have each of you chosen to focus attention on in your various captions?

ACTIVITY 7 EXTENSION

In pairs or groups, take a series of photographs around the school site. Make a wall display featuring these photographs, giving captions which alter the way a viewer might interpret them.

Where do newspapers get their photographs? There are three main sources:

- A photographer specifically sent to the scene of the story to cover the story will send back the best possible shots under the circumstances.
- Photos can be set up after the event where there is much more chance to pose the subjects and get a good composition.
- Photos not originally taken as news pictures are used because they are the only available images, for example school photographs of a missing child or images taken from security cameras.

Headlines

Good headlines are crucial, especially on the front page – this headline will draw a purchaser's attention to the paper when it is on the shelf among its competitors. Broadsheet editors will try to draw readers to their stories by using concise headlines which sometimes also give the newspaper's angle on the story, but tabloid headlines are large and catchy.

The Sun has become famous for its controversial headlines. Although these can be amusing, they sometimes cross the line from humour into bad taste. In 1989 the paper printed the headline THE TRUTH above an article about the Hillsborough football disaster in which 95 Liverpool fans were killed. *The Sun*'s 'truth' was that the disaster was caused by drunk Liverpool fans behaving badly. Sales of the paper in Liverpool collapsed, with many newsagents refusing to stock it, and have never recovered.

Techniques	Examples
Abbreviating names	David Beckham is usually 'Becks'.
Parody: taking a well known saying and giving it a slight twist	BRAWL OVER BAR THE SHOUTING
Incorrect or invented spelling	SVENTASTIC for football manager Sven-Goran Eriksson
Alliteration	BILL BOUNCES BACK
Pun: a play on words, often giving a double meaning	BOOTIFUL – winning goal in Cup Final
Rhyming	RIO GIVES HEAVE-HO TO THE MUMBO JUMBO

12 Tricks of the headline-writer's trade

ACTIVITY 8

1 In chart **12** you can see some techniques that headline writers use to draw readers in. Look through a copy of one of the tabloids. Try to find examples of headlines using any of these techniques.

2 Take any story from the same paper and try to make up your own headline using a different technique to the one already used by the paper.



13 The features of newspaper layout

Layout

When all the copy is written and all the photographs have been chosen, the final choices concern how the page is to be laid out. Layout is a key part of the battle to grab the reader's attention and hang on to it.

The **sub-editors** of the paper use computer technology to set out the pages. They work from a page grid that breaks the page into a series of columns. In the past pages were almost always set out in columns, with nothing breaking the grid pattern. Modern page design very often allows both photographs and text to spill outside rigid columns to create dramatic visual impact.

TIP

Knowing the terms to describe newspaper layout will help you to know what to look for when writing about them, and increase your marks.

In **13** a front page from *The Mirror* has been marked up with the terms used by sub-editors to describe modern newspaper layout.

Newspapers are constantly researching the ways in which people read pages. They have found, for example, that:

- headlines near photographs are read more than those placed further away
- using colour does not make a story more likely to be read
- people reading a paper look at most of the photographs, artwork and headlines – but much less of the copy.

Above all, a newspaper wants to achieve an individual visual style. This is about individual preferences. What people in Britain regard as good page design may not be what people in other countries like.

ACTIVITY 9

Look at the two European front pages in **14** and **15**.

1 Make some notes on the differences you notice between them, using the terms shown in **13**. You could use a chart like the one below.

Le Télégramme	Neue Zürcher Zeitung
Large main photo	*Small photo*

2 Now note down the differences you can find between each of these front pages and the British front page design in **13**.

KEY TERM

Sub-editor person responsible for the layout of a newspaper



Votre jardin. Les tendances du fleurissement estival. Page 49

0.75 €

Le Télégramme

CHATEAULIN

N° 17.977 VENDREDI 11 AVRIL 2003

BRETAGNE
TITRE DE REINE : UN TRÉSOR À PROTÉGER

SÉCURITÉ ROUTIÈRE : 100 € LA BANANE !

PNEUMOPATHIE : TRANSFERT D'UN BRESTOIS À RENNES

FRANCE
CONCORDE : FIN D'UNE LÉGENDE

SPORTS
2007 : LA COUPE DU MONDE EN FRANCE

L'IRAK FACE À SON DESTIN

Protectorat américain ? Administration sous le contrôle de l'ONU ? transition ? Alors que les combats se poursuivent, les Irakiens Pour l'heure, face à cet avenir incertain, les scènes de pillages et de Une situation anarchique à laquelle il est urgent de mettre fin.

E.LECLERC
QUIMPER
Préparez Pâques !
LANGUE DE BŒUF FRAÎCHE ORIGINE CEE
PINTADE FERMIÈRE LABEL ROUGE ORIGINE SUD-OUEST
QUEUES DE L

14 The front page from French newspaper *La Télégramme*, 11 April 2003



Freitag, 5. Februar 1999 · Nr. 29

Der Zürcher Zeitung 220. Jahrgang

Neue Zürcher Zeitung

INTERNATIONALE AUSGABE

Heute mit: «Spektrum Deutschland»

Ausdehnung der Heroinversuche in Holland

HEUTE IN DER NZZ

INTERNATIONAL

Amnesty untersucht Gewalt in Nordirland

Die USA zum Eingreifen in Kosovo bereit

Kanzlerabstimmung in Rio de Janeiro

WIRTSCHAFT

Die «braune» Zeit der Deutschen Bank

SCHWEIZ

Krankenversicherungsgesetz unter der Lupe

Neutralität ist nicht Passivität

Kontroverse um Paul Grüninger

ZÜRICH

Neuregelung der Spitzenmedizin

FEUILLETON

Valerio Olgiatis Schulhaus in Paspels

SPORT

Gründung einer Anti-Doping-Agentur

VERMISCHTE MELDUNGEN

Kampagne gegen den Abergläuben in China

BEILAGE

Medien und Informatik

Inhaltsübersicht

Kämpfer der Befreiungsarmee Kosovo im Dorf Dragobilje (Bild ap)

Grünes Licht für Kosovo-Verhandlungen

Teilnahme von serbischen und albanischen Delegationen

Erneut Verurteilung eines chinesischen Dissidenten

Die jüngste Repressionswelle erfasst auch unautorisierte Arbeiterproteste

Der jordanische König in kritischem Zustand

Starker Druck auf Belgrad

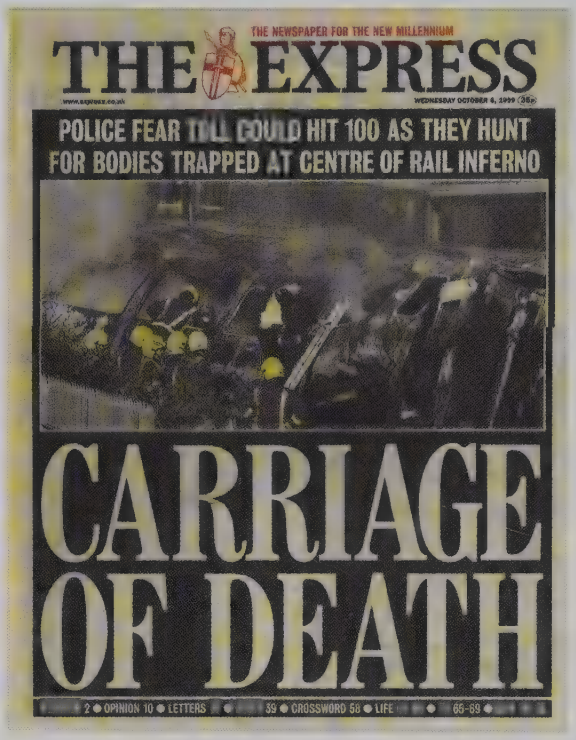
Neue Zeile der Demokratischen Partei

Demonstration bei Hamburg gegen den Atomausstieg

15 This newspaper was published in Germany on 5 February 1999

Fact?

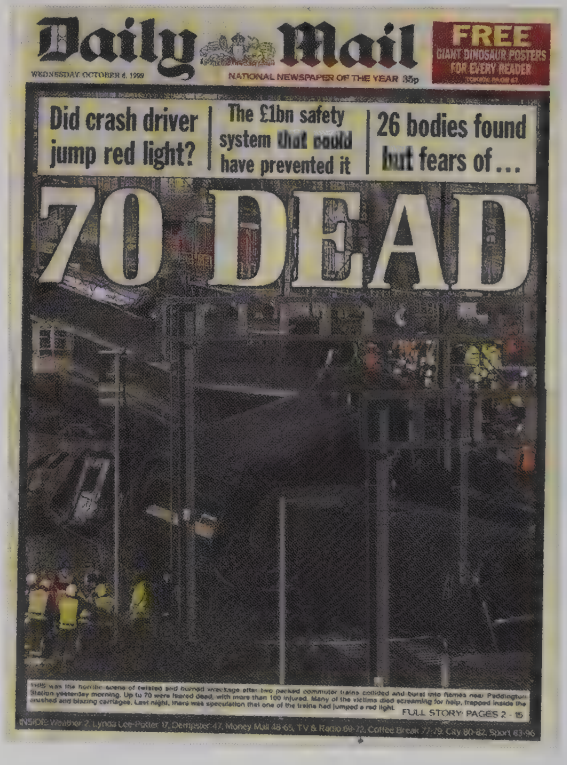
John Walter seemed to think that newspapers should mainly report facts. The three front pages shown in images **16** to **18** appeared on the day after the Paddington rail disaster in 1999. They show that sometimes the facts can be a bit different, depending on which paper you are reading them in.



16 Front page of the *Daily Express*, 6 October 1999



18 Front page of *The Mirror*, 6 October 1999



17 Front page of the *Daily Mail*, 6 October 1999

KEY TERMS

Leader article where the paper's editor or owner says what they think about a particular issue

News sources the various places where journalists get their stories

Positive representation presenting a favourable view of individuals, groups or ideas

Press release information provided to newspapers by a variety of organisations (government departments, charities, pressure groups, etc.)

ACTIVITY 11

Discuss in pairs *why* you think each newspaper chose the front page it did.

1 Why did *The Daily Express* use a higher number? Why did the splash head then choose a different emphasis?

2 Why did the other two papers present the number of dead as a fact?

Opinion

It is often not the facts that are given but the opinions of the reporters, editors or their sources that introduce an angle. Sometimes the papers make it obvious that they are expressing an opinion. **Leader articles** on the Editorial page set out what the paper's editor or owner thinks should be done about a particular issue. These usually discuss serious topics – whether Britain should join the Euro or whether it should go to war, for example.

But often the way news events are reported builds a certain point of view into the story. In this case the angle is governed by the choices editorial staff make – the paper chooses the viewpoint it wants to put across to its readers.

News is often reported in terms of *heroes* and *villains*. Sometimes it is easy. Saddam Hussein was rarely represented as anything other than an out-and-out villain who had killed thousands of his own people and spent Iraq's oil wealth on himself. However, sports personalities and teams often swing quickly from being heroes to villains and back again within a matter of days. News reports always try to tell a story.

ACTIVITY 12

Using a copy of any national daily newspaper, find three stories that present the reader with clear heroes and villains.

1 Which words from the articles make you think that one person is the 'goody' and the other is the 'baddy'?

2 Are any pictures used to support the view you are given of the characters in the piece?

News sources

It is important to know about **news sources** because how newspapers represent the news of the day is affected by the sources from which that news comes.

Over 60 per cent of all newspaper stories come from **press releases** or press conferences. A busy local paper will often print a well written press release, following the Five Ws and KISS rules, almost as it stands. If you want your school play to be given a good press, you need a good press release, describing your 'gripping' performance of a 'much loved classic' play. In Media Studies terms, you will have achieved a **positive representation** of the production.

ACTIVITY 13

Write a press release for an event in your area. This could be a sports event, a live music concert, a non-uniform day – anything you think your local paper ought to cover. Remember the Five Ws and KISS!

Generally speaking, local newspapers get their news from:

- Agendas for meetings, e.g. the County Council, the local Health Authority Trust, the Steam Railway Preservation Society
- Press releases sent by email and post from various organisations
- Police or Fire and Rescue services
- News Agencies such as the Press Association and Reuters
- Members of the public telling the paper of incidents or events
- Contacts: people the paper's journalists call regularly to see if they have a story; occasionally these people will call the paper to tip them off about an event.

This list might lead you to think that journalists could go to many different places to **source** their news. However, research has shown that they use a remarkably limited range. If the sources are limited then so will be the view of the world the papers give us.

Journalists put sources into the following three categories:

Primary sources: the courts, police, fire service, Members of Parliament, organisations representing business and industry, trade unions, football clubs

Secondary sources: schools, churches, charities, representatives of pressure groups such as Friends of the Earth

Alternative sources: representatives of religions other than Christianity, ethnic minority groups, feminist, lesbian and gay groups, anti-war groups such as CND, representatives of political parties other than the main three.

Critics say that the routines used by journalists for sourcing news mean that their stories reflect the distribution of power in the country. People from the leading groups and institutions have easier access to the press and so their views are heard more often. Representatives from 'alternative' groups get little or no press coverage and this reinforces their powerlessness in society.

ACTIVITY 14

1 Examine any national or local newspaper. Choose three news stories. Try to work out which news sources might have provided each story. Use this list to help you:
   - A press conference given by an organisation
   - A press release from an organisation
   - Parliament
   - The emergency services
   - Member of the public directly contacting the paper
   - A detailed investigation by one of the paper's reporters.

2 Choose one of the three stories that seems to have a clear angle on the events it describes. What would the alternative viewpoint be on this story? Where might the journalist have had to go to get an alternative angle?

KEY TERM

Source find information to use when writing news stories

News values

Most journalists will tell you that selecting the right stories for the day is a matter of experience and instinct. But in a famous study in 1973 Galtang and Ruge found that these factors help a story to get into the news:

- *Timescale:* a murder is committed and discovered quickly, so it fits the timescale on which newspapers work. An increase in gun crime, which happens over a long period, will only get reported when there are a series of gun-related crimes.
- *The size of an event:* A rail crash killing 25 people is big news; a train derailment with no injuries is not.
- *How clear the event is:* News need not be simple, but a very complicated story will probably get left out.
- *Predictability:* If the press expects something to happen then it will. A big anti-capitalist demonstration planned for central London will get reported, even if it passes off peacefully, because the press expect violence and send journalists to cover it.
- *Continuity:* A running story, like a war, will continue to be covered.
- *Reference to elite people or nations:* News about the USA or their president is more likely to get covered than similar news from Costa Rica.

News coverage is often **ethnocentric**. How do newspapers, and other media, report on less developed countries? These nations appear in the news when there are famines, natural disasters, violent revolutions or political corruption. Readers are invited to be thankful that they live in a stable country, where everyone has the basics of life and is fairly and honestly governed. But can it *really* be true that nothing good ever happens in the developing world?

Newspapers are said to give a 'window on the world', but in reality they give the view from a window facing in only one direction. Behind the other three walls there are all sorts of things going on, but they do not get reported.

ACTIVITY 15

1 Conduct your own survey into the news values of one tabloid daily paper for a week. Without reading them in full, complete a tally chart like the one below.
   - Count the total number of news stories each day.
   - Count the number of stories about Africa each day, adding that as a second column to your chart.
   - Of the stories which you found about Africa, make a note of how many were giving good news about the country and how many were reporting problems.

Day	News stories	Stories about Africa	Good news	Bad news
Monday	17	3	1	2

2 At the end of the week, choose the three 'biggest' news stories. Try to work out how many of the points on Galtang and Ruge's list apply to each story.

KEY TERM

Ethnocentric biased towards events in the country in which the paper is produced

Newspaper audiences

Why do newspapers need to know about their audiences?

The running costs of a newspaper have to be covered by:

- money from the sale of newspapers, which depends on the **circulation figure**
- money provided by advertisers taking space in the paper. The bigger the **readership**, the more they can charge people to advertise.

Just like any other media industry, it is very important for newspapers to know how large their readership is and how that readership breaks down in terms of gender and social class.

Advertising has an obvious effect on the way a paper looks. **Display adverts** create visual impact. In fact, when sub-editors lay up a page they put in the advertisements first.

- Some papers try to avoid placing adverts on certain pages, such as the front page.
- Advertisers sometimes pay more to ensure their product is the only one advertised on a page.
- Advertisers try to avoid the sports pages, so the remaining pages may have a high proportion of advertising content.
- It is the adverts, not the news, which determine how many pages an issue has: more adverts, a bigger paper!

How do newspapers find out about their readers?

Both advertisers and newspapers classify their readership into **socio-economic groups**; readers in the A, B and C1 categories will have more money to spend on things they see advertised.

Within those categories, newspapers use information from the National Readership Survey about different genders, particular interest groups – like car drivers or home owners – and age groups. You can see information from the NRS website in **19**. Just to be sure the newspapers are telling them the truth, advertisers can go to the Audit Bureau of Circulation, which checks that circulation figures are correct.

KEY TERMS

Circulation figure number of copies sold of any one newspaper

Display advert advert that takes up quite a lot of the page and often uses a big colour photo

Readership number of people who read a particular newspaper: its 'audience'. This figure is larger than the circulation because one copy can be read by several people.

Socio-economic groups researchers classify people into six categories, A, B, C1, C2, D and E, based mainly on the work they do

TIP

You can find the very latest information about readership by visiting the websites of The National Readership Survey and the Audit Bureau of Circulation via Heinemann Hotlinks.

Daily Newspapers Monday to Saturday Average readership	Adults													
	Total adults		ABC1		C2DE		15–44		45+		Men		Women	
	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%
The Sun	9229	19.6	3267	12.9	5962	27.3	5652	23.6	3577	15.5	5220	22.8	4009	16.5
Daily Mail	5979	12.7	3955	15.7	2024	9.3	2093	8.7	3886	16.8	3022	13.2	2957	12.2
Daily Mirror	5146	10.9	1990	7.9	3155	14.4	2318	9.7	2828	12.2	2727	11.9	2419	10.0
Daily Telegraph	2306	4.9	1967	7.8	339	1.6	702	2.9	1604	6.9	1268	5.5	1038	4.3
Daily Express	2181	4.6	1307	5.2	874	4.0	767	3.2	1414	6.1	1161	5.1	1020	4.2
Daily Star	1894	4.0	649	2.6	1245	5.7	1347	5.6	547	2.4	1362	6.0	533	2.2
The Times	1865	4.0	1635	6.5	230	1.1	894	3.7	971	4.2	1115	4.9	750	3.1
Metro	1498	3.2	973	3.9	525	2.4	1139	4.7	359	1.6	874	3.8	624	2.6
The Guardian	1332	2.8	1144	4.5	189	0.9	771	3.2	562	2.4	776	3.4	557	2.3
The Independent	584	1.2	497	2.0	87	0.4	308	1.3	276	1.2	370	1.6	214	0.9

19 Information from the National Readership Survey, June 2002–June 2003